

Readings

Who ever got this idea that we could have pleasure without pain? It's promoted rather widely in this world, and we buy it.

- Pema Chodron

To truly laugh, you must be able to take your pain, and play with it!

- Charlie Chaplin

All great spirituality is about what we do with our pain

- Richard Rohr

I Can Feel the Suffering of Millions

By Anne Frank

I can feel the suffering of millions
and yet, if I look up into the heavens,
I think it will all come right,
and that this cruelty too will end,
and that peace and tranquility will return again.
In the meantime,
I must uphold my ideals,
for perhaps the time will come
when I shall be able to carry them out.

Embracing the Double-Edged Universe - By Kyle Johnson

A dark treeline against a light grey sky
Mystery of the Universe –
You who some think of not as a being among other beings,
But as the very Ground of Being Itself –
Thank you for this day,
For another sunrise,
Another chance for us to witness the wonder of Creation.

We know that yours is a Creation that is truly double-edged –
A “yin-yang” Universe –
For it is indeed one in which the life giving flame can also burn.
But it is also one in which the dark, cold, misting rain
Gives re-birth to spring.
And it is one in which, paradoxically, our acquaintance with pain and
sorrow can help us better appreciate pleasure and joy.

Help us, then, to have the courage and strength to embrace it All,
To embrace what is.

Help us – we, who are similarly double-edged,
Whose love for those closest to us
Can so easily provoke our own tribal instincts and prejudices;
Whose own pain, rather than fostering empathy and compassion,
May turn us inward,
to dig moats, to build walls, rather than bridges.

So help us to embrace this double-edged, yin-yang Universe
with courage and strength,
But above all, help us to do so in a spirit of love and compassion –
For this, it seems, is our eternal challenge,
As it is also the wellspring of our eternal salvation.

Pain and Religion

I spent maybe 6 weeks with two different families in the ICU waiting room. A young man had come into our hospital's emergency room under his own power, but after he was settled into a hospital bed, he never got up again. He was handsome and kind. His new wife was lovely and young. She, her parents, and his parents, came to the ICU waiting room every day. The patient developed ARDS, Acute respiratory distress syndrome. In response to an illness or injury, fluid fills up the tiny air sacs in the lungs, making breathing difficult. Eventually it becomes impossible.

The chaplaincy staff walked a fine line with these two families. The young man's parents were mature in their mainline Christian faith. It was tearing them up to watch their boy decline. They struggled with holding on to hope for his recovery - he was young and strong and had a chance of getting better. ARDS kills most of its victims.

The young woman's parents belonged to a large, non-denominational, evangelical church. They knew in their bones that they just needed to pray hard enough and God would heal their son-in-law.

This was an agonizing case for the staff. Though the patient's parents were right there, the wife was considered the next of kin. She and her family had primacy regarding his care. In time, the ICU waiting room became a divided and inhospitable battle ground. The young woman's parents kept themselves separated from the young man's. They did not want to pick up any of their negative energy, acknowledging that the patient could die. They needed to stay strong for the miracle to happen.

And the patient's parents did not like feeling shamed for acknowledging that they could lose their son. They trusted that God's presence would be with them no matter how this turned out. It was sad, these two deeply religious families were relying on their faith in an impossible situation. Each families' beliefs were helping them and yet making it harder on the other family. Religion brought comfort and encouragement, and at the same time, brought estrangement and

confusion. Who is to say when belief makes a difficult situation harder?

This morning is our third and final sermon in our series of pain. We started with "The Problem of Pain," looking at our theological, cultural and personal difficulties regarding pain. Next we examined the backward gifts that come to us in "The Purpose of Pain." Today we are considering "Pain and Religion."

Religion itself is a double-edged sword. History is replete with stories of religious persecution, wars, and perverse political partnerships; atrocities committed in the name of faith. Equally, there are tails of improved lives, mended bodies, and advanced communities brought about by religion.

Pain is also a great conundrum. There is no easy way to wrap our minds around the benefits and burdens attached to distress and hardship. The relationship and interaction between these two enigmas of pain and religion make a big Gordian Knot.

Richard Rice writes: *"The experience of suffering presents us with a number of perplexing paradoxes. For most of human history, disease and death were part of everyday experience. People faced the pain life brought, did their best to cope with it, and moved on. Ironically, however, the more effective our attempts have become to resist disease and death, the more perplexing they seem to be. Now, thanks to medical science, people suffer much less in life than they would have in the past, yet they are more upset by it than before. The less we have to suffer, it seems, the more our suffering bothers us."* (Richard Rice - *Some Thoughts On Pain And Suffering* - Spectrum - October 21, 2016)

Dr. J Ungar notes: *"Before the advent of modern pain management interventions, pain was seen as a natural part of life, carrying a variety of religious, cultural, and societal meanings. It has been argued that when ether and chloroform were introduced into obstetrics in the 19th century, pain became a medical matter that lost*

much of its spiritual meaning in the medical community.” (Dr. J.Y. Ungar - Chronic Pain and Spirituality - Neurology and Pain Management)

Initially there was blow back when doctors started using anesthesia for childbirth. Some were concerned that relieving women of labor pains might be depriving them of the discipline God had bestowed on them as a consequence of original sin. Fortunately, the western Christian church was a strong advocate for the relief of suffering whenever possible. Using medical aids to avoid physical distress was not seen as a hindrance to one's spiritual character.

Here is where things start getting tricky. On one hand, the Christian Church generally tells people that medicine is a gift from God and if their malady can be lessened, they should follow their doctor's orders. On the other hand, there are times when people are told that it is God's will that they should struggle and God will help them in their distress. One of the reasons I left the denomination I had served was because I could not, in good conscience, tell a woman that God made men the rulers of their households and it was her Christian duty to stay in an abusive relationship.

For the sake of this sermon, I am going to use the words religion, spirituality, believers and the faithful in very broad terms. This is a big topic and we are going to look at the larger picture. Clearly there are differences between different religions. Additionally, the religious liberals of any group have more in common with the religious liberals of different religions than they have in common with the fundamentalists of their own faith. So, let's agree in advance that this sermon does not speak definitively for any particular belief system. Instead, we'll be dealing with broad brush strokes.

In times past, the basic theology of a religion guided its followers in matters of distress and suffering. For example, Hinduism held that the cause for discomfort and misfortune was karma. People's misdeeds result in just and appropriate payback, either in the present life, or in one to follow. Karma is not a punishment; it is a natural

consequence. It is a justice system that balances out the good and the bad. Avoiding the consequences of karma is only putting off the inevitable. The believers' duties were to bear the negative situation and plan to do better in the future.

Buddhists believe that desire is the cause of affliction. Humans have a misperception of the real world and its impermanence. The way to freedom is to look past false illusions and let go of the material world. The less you want or cling on to what you have, the less you hurt.

Muslims begin with the understanding that everything that happens comes about because of the will of Allah. Since Islam means "to submit," it follows that the believer should submit to whatever Allah places upon their lives. Trusting that Allah has a purpose for each ache and wound makes submitting more bearable.

Christianity has a mixed theology; on one hand a follower of Christ is obligated to accept whatever discipline the Almighty lays upon them. On the other hand, there is also an expectation that the blessings of God bring freedom from undue hardship and distress.

Judaism, also has a blended attitude toward affliction. Jewish humor and story often carry an element of guilt and martyrdom, yet the core belief underneath it is that devout worship of the Divine should ultimately bring one to the land of milk and honey.

New Age religion holds that before birth, individual and collective souls decide on the lessons they want to learn in their upcoming life. The vicissitudes of life are what they agreed to before coming to the earth.

Pagans generally accept that pain and suffering are part of life and they should live honorably while dealing with them. Pagans call upon various spirits and gods, and use magic, spells, and rituals while trying to lessen life's upsets and promote healing.

Native American and African religious groups have different understandings regarding the adversity of life. For some, malignant spirits and an individual's being out of balance can be the basis for harm. For others, trials and tribulations are a natural part of life.

Either way, there are no prohibitions against seeking remedies for trouble.

This brief and simplistic tour of world religions gives us a small window into the ways various groups understand pain's origins and how that directs the ways they address it. We have an additional matter in our north western world views. As our societies become less homogenous and as our knowledge increases about health and pain management, culture adds an increasingly directive voice about burdensome situations. It is harder to swallow the idea of learning from your pain than it is to swallow some Excedrin Migraine pills. It is harder to stomach the payback of karma when you can take Pepto-Bismol or Tums. In an earlier sermon we examined society's censorship of pain.

In talking about pain and religion today, I've divided our topic into 4 primary categories:

1. Pain Caused By Religion
2. Pain Helped By Religion
3. Pain Healed By Religion
4. Pain Endured For Religion

Religion in general is responsible for an ungodly amount of pain and suffering. It is easy to begin by naming some of the direct ways belief has battered countries and large groups of people. It has waged war, persecuted other faiths, joined with particular political groups to reach shared goals, and amassed wealth and land at the expense of ordinary people. The scandal of the sexual abuse of children by priests is particularly insidious. The harm continues to ripple out into the world. Religious history is painful to read. It is impossible to reconcile communities who preach peace and hospitality for the stranger with the stories of missionaries extinguishing native populations or Christians requiring Jews to be baptized as believers of Christ, then holding their heads underwater until they drowned so they couldn't recant their new found faith.

In a less direct manner, the teachings of religion have brought severe and lasting torment to millions of people. This is suffering caused by theology. Holy texts declare that women should be submissive to their own husbands. They say that two men should not have sex. They direct humankind to dominate the earth. They teach that the spirit is good and the body is bad. This list goes on for a very long time. Sadly, Holy literature will suggest something and people who have some power will take the ideas and carry them to extremes. All of you in this room can list a multitude of ways people are berated, constrained, abused and vilified, in the name of religion. The gravest concern is that religion has not stepped in soon enough to prevent the damage done by bad theology.

This is brought home on a smaller scale when it becomes religious trauma and spiritual abuse. When spiritual beliefs are forced upon vulnerable people, it is abuse. This is about power: The coach making the players pray before the game, the nurse holding the pain medication offering to read scripture to a patient, the soup kitchen providing a hot meal *after* the homeless have sat through a sermon. Anytime people with less power are subject to the good intentions of the religious, we have to wonder, was this wanted, or is it just compliance.

Belief forced on vulnerable people, including children, is a spiritual violation. When the religion has harsh teachings about personal worth, one's body and sexuality, and one's role in life, it becomes religious trauma. When the method and the message are damaging, the spiritual wound is deeper. The good news is that spiritual trauma can be healed. And like all healing, it is hard work.

Besides direct attacks and harmful teachings, religion also causes pain by passively discouraging growth. Karl Marx famously said, "religion ... is the opiate of the masses." Instead of insisting on personal and social maturation, religion can encourage people to continue living in awful circumstances. A religious group may believe they will receive a greater reward in heaven if they accept the yolk of suffering now. Or believers might see it as their duty to submit to

God's present will, trusting that the Divine has a plan or because it is the karmic consequence of a previous life's action. Some interpret hardship as God's punishment or test. Simply accepting and bearing the trials and tribulations people encounter relieves them of the risks inherent in change.

Religion can also stymie personal growth. You've heard me talk before about James Fowler, a psychologist and theologian, who developed a theory about spiritual development. It would be easy to do a sermon just on these 6 stages alone. What's important for today's service is to learn that many religious leaders intentionally discourage their congregations from growing beyond Stage 3, the Synthetic-Conventional Faith. In this stage, people don't see that they are in a belief system and they have trouble thinking outside of their religious "box." They become attached to their form of religion and become extremely upset when their beliefs are called into question.

In all fairness, Stage 4, the Individuative-Reflective stage is a difficult process that involves a lot of questioning and can be painful as a person deconstructs their faith to build something new. It takes a lot more work to lead people through this stage.

It is also much harder to control folks who have moved into stage 4 and beyond. They no longer join committees or pledge to the church because they are told by an authority that they are supposed to. If they do it, they do it because they want to. Religion usually runs smoother if everyone just stays on the same page!

When religion is the source of angst, it is difficult to comprehend how something that touts its goodness and proclaims to be so beneficial can be so evil. The terrible cutting by the religious sword happens by means of direct destruction, by teaching theology with toxic consequences, by violating spiritual boundaries, and by discouraging personal, collective, and social growth.

We don't usually talk in church about the ways religion has messed up. It's unpopular to ask you for your pledge money and then list the endless ways faith has failed and beliefs have made difficult situations even harder.

This might be a good time to remind you that religion and spirituality are often beneficial to the body, mind, spirit, and community. Over the last 30 years, science has started studying religion. At first, faithful people were incensed. How could the sacred be put under a microscope or poked at in a petri dish? Then, as study after study demonstrated positive findings, the idea of researching spirituality didn't seem so bad.

It turns out that people who are religious tend to be happier. Folks who belong to a spiritual community live longer. Individuals who meditate and pray experience more peace. None of the research has indicated that religion alone is the magic button that makes everything all better. Study after study does point to evidence that individuals and groups who make use of their spirituality have more resources for coping with hardship. More studies are showing that belief and spiritual practices can make new pathways in the brain and help people tap into the parts of the brain that provide more peace and joy.

Much of this is pretty common sense - religion helps people make meaning of their lives, and what is unbearable becomes manageable when there is a compelling reason for it. Good psychology and sociology can explain a number of ways healthy spirituality helps people deal with trouble.

Some of the ways spirituality makes a difference are not as easy to explain. One classic study had to do with administering an electric shock to the hands of volunteers. Each volunteer determined 80% of what they could bear for pain and that was the amount of the charge given to them for the test. During the test, the volunteers were shown either a painting of the Virgin Mary or Leonardo da Vinci's Lady with an Ermine. After looking at the picture for 30 seconds, the volunteers were zapped with electrical pulses for 12 seconds. Each time, they were asked to rank how painful the shocks were on a scale of zero to 100.

The Roman Catholic participants felt 12% less pain after seeing the Virgin Mary images and their scans revealed that an area of the brain that suppresses reactions to threatening situations, called the

ventrolateral prefrontal cortex, lit up when they were shown the Madonna picture.

The fact that these tests are based on observable, empirical, reproducible, measurable evidence, and subject to the laws of reasoning make this even more exciting! It is not “Kumbaya” or just touchy feely positive public relations for spirituality. There is something to be said for science and best practices.

Over the years this has been particularly important when I’ve gone before healthcare administration to lobby for a bigger spiritual care budget. In healthcare, chaplains don’t make money. Our time is not billable. We do, however, save a lot of money and resources. There is all sorts of supportive research that demonstrates decreased use of pain medications and fewer behavioral disturbances when chaplains are involved with patient and family care.

We’ve seen that faith and spiritual practices can make difficulties more tolerable. Next let’s look at instances where spirituality is the only medicine that will work. Sometimes this is physical distress that is managed with religious resources. Sometimes this is to address Spiritual Pain.

Physical discomfort can be exacerbated by non-physical causes such as fear, anxiety, grief, unresolved guilt, depression, and unmet spiritual needs. Likewise, the inability to manage physical distress well can be due to emotional or spiritual issues. When individuals suffer from loss of personhood, despair, and feelings of abandonment by God, traditional medicine will have little effect. Spiritual Care practitioners may take assessments, provide counseling, assign homework, and address concerns of forgiveness, reconciliation, hope, shame, and secrets.

Care for spiritual angst may use customary religious tools, such as prayer, holy texts, blessings, anointings, confession, smudging, chanting, visualization and other sacred remedies. At times, a spiritual crisis may call for non-religious approaches or creative experiments. Several times I’ve suggested people use a “damnit doll” as a first step

in attending to anger and rage. Several folks reported back that running over the doll with their car was particularly satisfying!

Prior to the regular use of medication for pain management, such distress was heaped under the category of spiritual concerns. As our world has grown more confident with many different ways to address affliction, we have been making room again for the use of spiritual care in soothing the wounds people endure.

Today there is one last area we're going to look at where pain and belief overlap: distressing religious rituals and rites. This section could easily be a study for several Sundays. I only have a few moments to tell you about it.

Almost all religions have a variety of experiences that run along a continuum from mild discomfort to excruciating anguish. Some are short lived, like a fast that misses only a meal. Others are practiced for a lifetime, such as the lifestyles of self-deprivation and exposure to the elements favored by the ascetics and mystics. Fasting can be abstinence from certain foods to refusing all food and drink. Fasts can be individual or communal, relatively short bits of time to fasts that last for weeks.

At the far end of the disturbing rites are the extreme rituals. This is way past the hair shirts, pilgrimages, and self-flagellation with ropes. These acts of worship involve endurance, blood and violence done to the body. The Thaipusam Hindu festival in Malaysia, the Urs Festival in Pakistan, The Native American Sun Dance, the Rite Of The Vattienti and the literal Crucifixions in the Philippines on Good Friday are all huge festivals, drawing the faithful (and now tourists), to witness and support their devotion. These rituals and more call for lengthy preparations, piercing the skin, face, chest, or hands and feet, or pushing out one's eyeballs with a knife. They are fantastical and horrible.

For the purpose of this sermon, there are two important factors to note. The first is that the people who are there witnessing and supporting the worshipers say that they are deeply blessed by these events. Several studies have found that joining in these rites creates social bonds and positive social engagement. Several sociological

experiments have demonstrated that people are more generous and kind after being at such a festival. When heart monitors have been hooked up to the people at the rituals, scientists often find that the heart beats sync up. As a matter of fact, the heart beats of the family members and the ritual participants who walk on burning coals match up so precisely, it is easy to see who is related to a fire walker just by looking at the output of the monitors. These extreme rituals unite communities for a time.

Not only do these rituals strengthen religious community relationships, they provide an unexpected benefit to the worshiper. Pain that is self-selected enhances feelings of control and calm. These acts of reverence and sacrifice can bestow feelings of cleansing, hope, encouragement, equilibrium and self-possession.

Similar feelings might be experienced in secular settings. They miss out on the spiritual kick and the connection with the Divine and the universe. The same phenomena can show up in a negative light, such as when teenage girls and others practice cutting or food restriction.

When pain that is chosen and administered by an individual is paired intentionally with higher spiritual values, such as service, faith, love and growth, there is an impressive alchemy. A dangerous stunt or a difficult feat becomes an act of worship and renewal, for the participant as well as the supporters.

This sermon series on pain has led us to some unexpected conclusions. Pain itself is not our problem. It is how we think about it and try to escape it that gets in our way.

Pain carries many benefits. Our world would be more dangerous and we would be smaller, shallower people if we didn't heed the wisdom of pain. Pain has a number of positive purposes in our lives.

And finally, pain and religion are intertwined. It is true, spirituality that has been misused causes harm. It is equally true that spirituality well applied can ease pain and reduce harm. Pain and Religion are double edged swords, they cut both ways.

True religion and philosophy acknowledge that every living being suffers arrows and wounds. Everything deals with pain and limitations, just because they also are alive

In closing, I leave you with these words from Richard Rohr,
"Spirituality is always eventually about what you do with your pain"

May your pains resolve into your deepest blessings.

Amen and Amen